



OIL PALM NEWS



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OIL PALM PROJECT SOLVES TRANSPORT CHALLENGES IN BUVUMA



Wilson Sserunjoji, the NOPP Focal Person and Senior Assistant- Chief Administrative Officer (SACAO) for Buvuma District.

Previously notorious for its lack of basic infrastructure, Buvuma Island, the largest among the Buvuma District islands on Lake Victoria in Uganda, has undergone a remarkable transformation thanks to the introduction of the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP). In less than five years, the previously impenetrable and poverty infested island has witnessed a boost in the resident's quality of life in part due to the establishment of new infrastructure such as roads and schools among others.

The NOPP Project is a government initiative implemented by the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF) in partnership with other agencies, with the overall goal of "inclusive rural transformation through oil palm investment." Buvuma, which is located 30km south of Jinja City and over 100km from the capital Kampala, has been facing connectivity challenges due to its geographical location but has now been

fully transformed thanks to the project.

One of the most noticeable improvements has been the construction of new community and farm access roads which have unlocked the island's transportation network. With the majority of people relying mostly on fishing, logging and charcoal production, the previous roads were narrow, pothole riddled and impassable during the rainy season. "For someone who has lived and worked on this island for over 25 years, the new roads are a blessing to us. We no longer worry when it rains. This has boosted trade and commerce as farmers are able to transport their produce to the market with minimal disturbance," says Wilson Sserunjoji, the NOPP Focal Person and Senior Assistant Secretary (SAS) for Buvuma District.

The roads have improved Buvuma almost two years before the first oil palm fruit is set to be harvested. "Oil palm has put Buvuma on the map. This has in turn led

to the boosting of other aspects of our economy like tourism. More people are now interested in visiting Buvuma due to its natural beauty. The same applies to hotel, restaurant and other investors looking to tap into that market. All of this would have been impossible without the National Oil Palm Project and the roads they have put in place" says Moses Chuna Kapolon, the Buvuma District Chief Administrative Officer (CAO).

With the increase in business activity in Buvuma, proprietors of public and for hire transportation have also reaped big. Jeff Katongole, a boda-boda rider says he now makes more money transporting people and goods across the island, which has also seen an increase in the number of taxis coming from the mainland. "Before I would wait at the ferry landing point and see only a handful of people coming or going. Nowadays, if I am not transporting people, I am transporting fresh food to and from the ferry. Business is really





Oil palm has put Buvuma on the map. This has in turn led to the boosting of other aspects of our economy like tourism. More people are now interested in visiting Buvuma due to its natural beauty. The same applies to hotel, restaurant and other investors looking to tap into that market. All of this would have been impossible without the National Oil Palm Project and the roads they have put in place

good,” he says with a broad smile.

In total, NOPP has facilitated the construction of over 200km of murrum roads across Buvuma. Of these, 150km are farm access roads and 50km being community access roads, confirms the CAO’s office. However, the impact of the project isn’t limited to transportation alone. Healthcare, education, utilities and other aspects of the society have generally improved thanks to the project.

In order to support project activities on the island, government allocated 5,440 hectares of land which for the project. Oil Palm Buvuma Limited (OPBL) is the investor company which is in charge of oil palm production in the district.

Having already established a 14 hectares of oil palm nursery in Buvuma, OPBL currently employs over 1,000 residents in various jobs such as lining, hauling, extension work, and driving among others. The investor expects to increase the number of jobs to 2,000 after constructing a mill and commencing the production of crude palm oil on the island. This commitment has been signified by the launch of a new state of the art ferry, the MV Palm in May 2023. The new ferry has a carrying capacity of 519 people and 25 vehicles and is part of the overall funding of the NOPP.



DEOGRATIUS AND ROSE: THE SIBLINGS NURTURING PROSPERITY THROUGH OIL PALM GROWING



Deogratius Muyimbwa and Rose Namuyimbwa

In the tranquil village of Bubanzi in the island district of Buvuma on Lake Victoria, two siblings, Deogratius Muyimbwa and Rose Namuyimbwa embarked on a journey to transform their lives. For generations, agriculture, especially the growing of bananas has been the traditional source of livelihood for their family. However, the siblings decided to take on the new oil palm farming after the introduction of the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) to Buvuma Island in 2021.

The NOPP is a government initiative funded by the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) and implemented by the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF) in partnership with other agencies.

When Deogratius joined Vegetable Oil Development Project (predecessor to NOPP) in 2007, he saw it as an opportunity to learn more about oil palm growing but was still on the fence about taking on the venture.

“Given that oil palm is a new crop in Buvuma, everyone including myself was skeptical about it. A crop that takes four

years to produce its first harvest was against every agricultural practice I had known since I started growing bananas. Even though there were a lot of challenges like pests, diseases, and fluctuating prices, I kept growing bananas as I learnt more about oil palm,” Muyimbwa reveals.

The turning point came in 2010 when Deogratius and others in Buvuma were taken on a training and benchmarking trip to Kalangala Islands where oil palm growing was first introduced on a large scale in Uganda. In Kalangala, they interacted with farmers who had transformed their lives through oil palm growing and told them about the benefits and long-term profitability of a generational crop like oil palm.

Kalangala farmers were earning significantly more and for longer (up to 30 years) from an acre of oil palm than the same sized banana plantation.

This revelation inspired Muyimbwa who in turn convinced his sister to start growing oil palm in 2021. Together, the siblings dedicated eight and three acres of their respective family land to grow oil palm while reserving the rest for banana farming for food security and other activities.

Under NOPP, they automatically became members and shareholders of the Buvuma Oil Palm Growers Cooperative Society Limited which caters for the interest of the farmers who will supply produce to the investor company, Oil Palm Buvuma Limited (OPBL) as part of the tripartite agreement including the government, OPBL and the farmers.

“Our decision to grow oil palm has been well supported and encouraged by NOPP and other stakeholders. They have made our transition easier by educating us, providing technical assistance, fertilizer and most importantly funding to help clear and maintain our oil palm gardens,” Namuyimbwa says.

As part of the project, Muyimbwa and Namuyimbwa received UGX 4.8m and UGX 1.6m respectively to clear and maintain their gardens. This same credit has been extended to all 601 registered oil palm farmers under their cooperative society and has since resulted in the fast adoption of the project. According to official records, Buvuma smallholder farmers have so far planted 1,320 hectares of oil palm, which is more than half of the planned 2,500 hectares by 2025.

However, there have been challenges with land acquisition and the competing livelihoods between oil palm growers and other farmers on the Island. A status-quo, officials are sure, will change once the first oil palm fruit is harvested in Buvuma.

The precursory benefits of oil palm growing are undeniably visible across the island; the introduction of a new state of the art ferry, MV Palm, is set to improve transportation to and from the island; the construction of over 200km of murram community and farm access roads have rendered the island motorable; the employment of over 1,000 residents by OPBL to support oil palm production and the construction of an upcoming mill; the establishment of new schools, hospitals and offices are the reassurances of the faith that Muyimbwa, Namuyimbwa and hundreds of farmers in Buvuma put into oil palm growing.



MV PALM: THE CROWN JEWEL OF BUVUMA'S IMMINENT OIL PALM TRANSFORMATION



Officially launched on 27 May 2023, by the Minister of Works and Transportation, Gen. Edward Katumba Wamala, the MV Palm ferry is as imposing and reassuring as the bright future expected to be visited on the Island of Buvuma thanks to the introduction of oil palm growing, under the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) in 2021.

Measuring 44 meters in length and 14.6 meters in width, the MV Palm weighs a whopping 665 metric tons and boasts a carrying capacity of 239 metric tons. This translates to a provision to carry 519 seated passengers and 25 vehicles to and from Buvuma and Buikwe on Lake Victoria.

MV Palm is the largest of the 12 ferries operated by the Uganda National Roads Authority (UNRA). MV Palm doubles the capacity of its predecessor, MV Kiyindi-Buvuma.

In order to move all this massive weight, MV Palm is propelled by four 235 kilowatt engines that were manufactured to the latest and safest international maritime standards, ensuring the safe transportation of people and goods across lake waters.

The ferry is set to solve the need for larger and faster means to transport the increasing amount of agriculture produce from the islands of Buvuma and Buikwe.

Originally known for the production of fish, bananas, pineapples, vegetables, charcoal and timber, the island of Buvuma which is the largest of the 52 Islands that make up Buvuma District, has been able to expand its prospects into sectors like tourism, hospitality and recreation. This has seen a rise in the number of people visiting and investing in the island.

This remarkable transformation can be attributed to the introduction of NOPP, a government initiative funded by the International Fund for Agricultural

Development (IFAD) and implemented by the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and

Fisheries (MAAIF) in partnership with other stakeholders such as Oil Palm Buvuma Limited (OPBL), an investor company in charge of oil palm production, primary processing; and the Buvuma Oil Palm Growers Cooperative Society Limited which caters for the interests of the farmers.

Facilitated by funding from IFAD, NOPP under MAAIF signed a contract worth USD 3,360,500 with M/S Songoro Marine Limited in December 2018 for the design, build and supply of MV Palm.



MV Palm Ferry



ALTERNATIVE LIVELIHOOD: NANTEZA'S JOURNEY FROM ILLEGAL FISHING TO SUSTAINABLE BACKYARD FARMING



Approximately 30 kilometers off the shores of Lake Victoria, south of Jinja City in Uganda lies the island of Buvuma. Sitting on a land mass of 200 square miles, Buvuma is the largest of the 52 islands that constitute the District of Buvuma. Apart from subsistence agriculture, logging and charcoal burning, fishing has been the major source of livelihood for the island's inhabitants for generations. Among these fishers was Yvonne Nanteza, a hardworking single mother of two whose run in with fishery authorities shattered her source of livelihood and changed her life forever.

For years, Nanteza plied her illegal trade on the landing site of Tojwe in Buvuma where she earned a meager income. In early 2022, the tide turned against her when the government's Fisheries Protection Unit (FPU) cracked down on illegal fishing in Tojwe and other landing sites across Uganda. "The authorities destroyed my boat and burnt my fishing nets. I was lucky not to end up in jail, but I was also confused on how to earn a living after my equipment was destroyed," says Nanteza.

Her only source of livelihood suddenly severed, Nanteza slid into depression and extreme poverty. She could barely afford to feed and educate her children who subsequently became malnourished and also dropped out of school. Living in a small mud house on a 7x14m plot of land in Tojwe, Nanteza was oblivious to the potential of turning her life around through farming, until the introduction of the Alternative Livelihood Programme (ALP).

The ALP is the second component of the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) which is aimed at benefitting residents that are unable to engage in oil palm growing due to lack of land and capital. Under ALP, beneficiaries are equipped with alternative life skills such as backyard agriculture, bee keeping, and animal rearing among others.

"We selected Tojwe as the first project site due to its difficult location. It is trapped between a forest reserve, oil palm fields and the landing site which was closed due to illegal fishing. The people now live in conditions similar to a camp with minimal space to live or engage in oil palm growing," says Francis Tugezeeko, the Community Development Officer (CDO) for Nairambi Subcounty in Buvuma.

By introducing a backyard farming project to the people of Tojwe, local leaders intended to improve the lives of non-oil palm growers, preserve the environment and mitigate inequalities between oil palm and non-oil palm growing communities. "This project was aimed at solving the most critical problems faced by



the communities of Tojwe and Koja; food insecurity and the lack of income. It is amazing how we have transformed society with funding of only UGX 5m from the NOPP,” says Steven Kibuuka, an Agricultural Officer and Focal Person for the Backyard Farming Project.

Together with 67 other beneficiaries, Nanteza enrolled for the project and underwent transformational training on how to farm and maximize yields on a limited plot of land. The trainings included mindset change, nursery bed management, garden preparing, crop protection, post-harvest handling and management, and general agronomy. “The trainings and technical support we received from extension workers was commendable. Many of us had never imagined a life as farmers but this project transformed us. They gave us free seeds, pesticides and fertilizer to boost our yields,” says Nanteza.

In October 2022, with the help of project extension workers, Nanteza set up her backyard farm consisting of tomatoes, bananas, eggplants, spinach and onions. Within less than two months, she had begun harvesting and benefitting from her farm — selling some of the produce and using the rest to feed her household. The project has enabled Nanteza to get back on her feet financially and send her two daughters back to school. The mother of two has resolved to expand her farming activities by setting up a 15x15 meter cassava garden.

Based on the preliminary outcomes of the Alternative Livelihood Programme in Buvuma, Tugezeeko described the initiative as a resounding success and recommends that government scales it up to other similar communities on the island.

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BUVUMA WILL CONTINUE ITS UPWARD TRAJECTORY AFTER EMBRACING OIL PALM GROWING – BUVUMA CAO



Moses Chuna Kapolon, the Chief Administrative Officer (CAO) of Buvuma District

As a testament to the substantial transformation of Buvuma Island due to the implementation of the government's National Oil Palm Project (NOPP), Moses Chuna Kapolon, the Chief Administrative Officer (CAO) of Buvuma District has predicted that the project will transform the island district for the foreseeable future. "Despite NOPP being an oil palm related project, we have witnessed the largescale revitalization of other sectors like transport and infrastructure, service delivery, community well-being and a promising commitment to sustainable development. Based on these early signs, I believe Buvuma will continue its upward trajectory for decades to come," said Kapolon.

Launched in Buvuma 2021, NOPP is a government initiative funded by the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) and implemented

by the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF) in partnership with other agencies. The project was designed with the overall goal of "inclusive rural transformation through oil palm investment." The NOPP involves all key stakeholders and potential beneficiaries of the oil palm economy, namely; government, investors (Oil Palm Buvuma Limited – OPBL), oil palm growers (Buvuma Oil Palm Growers Cooperative Society – BOPGco), and non-oil palm growers through the Alternative Livelihood Programme (ALP) and Household Mentorship components of the project.

By undertaking a holistic and inclusive approach to the project, all residents of Buvuma (estimated population of 89,890 per 2014 National Population and Housing Census) regardless of whether they grow oil palm or not, collectively feel attached to the project and have contributed to its

successful implementation. "Despite the challenges, NOPP's success has exceeded our expectations, considering that we haven't started harvesting oil palm fruits. Before, many of our people faced food insecurity and limited income prospects, especially when government cracked down on illegal fishing. As of today, a large percentage of those issues have been solved by the project. This is evidenced by the transformation of the lives of our people," Kapolon elaborates.

Rising Infrastructure and Oil Palm Growing

One of the most significant achievements of NOPP is the improvement of Buvuma's infrastructure. In 2013, when OPBL established a 14 hectare, 5,000 oil palm tree nursery in Buwangwe, this created 1,000 jobs for the residents as drivers, extension workers, planters and haulers. In order to facilitate the expansion of the



project to outgrowers across Buvuma, a total of 200km murrum roads were constructed, with 50km being community access roads and 150km being farm access roads. The new roads have boosted the transportation of goods and people across the island, hence boosting the local economy. The new infrastructure isn't limited to roads. It includes schools, staff houses, health centers, a new ferry (MV Palm), and an upcoming crude oil palm mill expected to create 1,000 new jobs.

According to official statistics, Buvuma has so far planted 1,320 out of the 2500 targeted hectares of oil palm, with more than 600 farmers across four subcounties of Busamuzi, Buvuma, Nairambi and Buwooya. All farmers are registered members who own shares in their cooperative society (BOPGco) which grants them access to technical support, subsidized loans, farm inputs via a hub office established under the project. In regards to harvesting, oil palm farmers are also guaranteed a ready market at competitive and steady market prices for their produce by OPBL.

Hope For Non-Oil Palm Growers

Under the Alternative Livelihood Programme (ALP) and Household Mentorship components of the project, non-oil palm growers have received training and technical support to promote the income, nutritional and social sustainability of their lives. In Tojwe in Buvuma, a former fish landing site that was shut down over illegal fishing, ALP has trained 68 farmers (mostly women) in backyard farming as an alternative to illegal fishing and the land demanding oil palm growing. Within three months, the farmers have transformed their lives through the selling and consumption of fruits and vegetables from their backyard farms.

The household mentorship programme has contributed to the reduction of gender-based violence, the spread of HIV/AIDS and other impacts of poverty among families in Buvuma according to district officials. Working with local government leaders, eligible families are trained in goal setting, conflict resolution, financial responsibility among other aspects. Upon completion of the course, they are given startup ALP projects like bee keeping, backyard farming, piggery, poultry, and also linked to other government poverty alleviation programs like the Parish Development Model (PDM).

Environmental Protection

The NOPP was designed with the preservation and rehabilitation of Buvuma's environment in mind. Occupying a land mass of 200 square miles, Buvuma is home to 26 gazetted forest reserves. The project has taken significant efforts to ensure their preservation. Of the 8,629 hectares of land allocated to OPBL by government, only 5,000 will be used for oil palm growing. The rest will host buffer zones for the lake and forest reserves.

"NOPP has established a tree nursery bed with mostly native species. We have also planted 4,000 which have greatly improved the restoration of the forests. Alternative Livelihood Programme activities like backyard farming and bee keeping have also contributed to the protection of the forests. Backyard farmers have been well sensitized not to encroach on forest reserves while bee keepers act as community policemen since their hives are within the forests. The bees also play a key role in the ecosystem by pollinating the flowers," says Wilson Serunjoji, the NOPP Focal Person and Senior Assistant Secretary (SAS) for Buvuma District.

Challenges, Way Forward

According to Kapolon, the Buvuma District CAO, there are still two major stumbling blocks to the full implementation of the project; the delay in valuing of land, and the compensation of owners by government. Once these issues are solved, the project will fully live up to its billing. Looking ahead, Kapolon envisions a bright future for Buvuma. "NOPP is a very good venture that has already exhibited its potential to enrich our people for generations. I express my thanks to government, IFAD and all stakeholders who have contributed towards the realization of this project. The people of Buvuma will forever be grateful for these efforts," he concludes.



NOPP CHANGING THE LIVES OF ORPHANS AND VULNERABLE THROUGH VOCATIONAL TRAINING



In the non-oil palm growing communities of Kalangala District in Central Uganda, the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) has been transforming the lives of orphans and vulnerable youth in more ways than one. Funded by the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) and implemented by the Ministry of Agriculture Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF) in partnership with other agencies, the initiative has been a turning point in the lives of vulnerable youth and orphans who have lost their parents to HIV, Gender Based Violence (GBV) and poverty among others.

“Before the introduction of the NOPP to Kalangala, we conducted an assessment about the negative impacts that earlier oil palm growing projects may have caused or accelerated in the community. We discovered that a growing financial gap between non-oil palm growers and oil palm growers had resulted in financial illiteracy, gender-based violence, rise in

the spread of HIV and other after effects. That is why we included social mitigation and resilience components within the NOPP,” explains Jude Tadeo Musaaazi, the District Community Development Officer (DCDO) for Kalangala.

Through equipping orphans and vulnerable youth with vocational skills, many have been able to improve their lives and become contributors to society. Among them is Pauline Nakato, 19, a young woman who lost her father at a tender age and dropped out of school in Primary Six. Having been enrolled for a six-month hairstyling course at Bumangi Community Polytechnic Institute Kalangala, she has since been able to set up her own unisex salon.

“Today I can proudly say that I am self-employed and able to sustain my life and that of my family. This wouldn’t have been possible if not for the help I received from NOPP and the great training from my teachers at Bumangi. I am thankful for their help,” says Nakato.

Br. Morris Kule, the registrar of Bumangi Polytechnic describes Nakato as a hardworking and curious student from the day she joined the school in January 2022 until her graduation in May the same year.

Bumangi was founded by the Masaka Catholic Church Diocese in 2000 to mitigate the spread of HIV/AIDS and cater for orphans and vulnerable youth. It is this shared goal that Br. Kule attributes for the success of NOPP’s vocational training program in Kalangala. “As an institution and on behalf of our alumni, we highly commend the decision by NOPP to sponsor orphans and vulnerable youth in acquiring vocational skills from Bumangi. Whether it is hairdressing, carpentry, catering, motor vehicle mechanics or any other vocational course, together we have witnessed and supported our students to change their lives,” says Br. Kule.



In total, 120 orphans and vulnerable youth have been sponsored by NOPP to acquire various vocational skills from Bumangi Polytechnic. Their impact in the community is self-evident. “Today the best furniture, restaurants, salons and tailor shops in Kalangala are either owned or employ a student from Bumangi. Their superior training, customer care and technical skills have made them highly sought after by employers and customers,” says Br. Kule.

Shortly after her graduation in May 2022, Nakato started working in her uncle’s retail shop which she supplemented by doing door to door hair dressing. In total, she would be able to save up to UGX 150,000 per month. In addition to that, she set up a poultry farm at her home which she jointly catered for with her mother and two siblings. By early 2023 she had saved enough money to open her salon which she christened, Smart Unisex Salon. “I named it Smart, because I noticed many men and women in the community were unable to access good and decently priced hairdressing services, so I started a salon that would give them a smart appearance at a good price,” Nakato reveals.

Since setting up her salon, Nakato’s life and those around her have been impacted. She is able to contribute towards her siblings’ school fees and family needs. She has taken on a single mother as an apprentice in the salon, and also joined a Village Savings and Loans Association group where she has been saving UGX 10,000 per month since April 2023. Nakato plans to purchase a plot of land in the future and set up the best salon of all in Kalangala.



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740 HOUSEHOLDS REHABILITATED THANKS TO NOPP MENTORSHIP PROGRAMME – KALANGALA OFFICIALS



According to official figures by Kalangala District, 740 households have so far enrolled and benefited from the household mentorship programme, a social mitigation and resilience component of the government's National Oil Palm Project (NOPP). "Within a period of two years, we have been able to mentor and rehabilitate 240 households in Kalangala, with another 500 currently undergoing the training. These are families that were identified by community leaders due to their poverty, HIV prevalence, gender-based violence and other social challenges," says Jude Tadeo Musaaazi, the District Community Development Officer (DCDO) for Kalangala.

Following the implementation of oil palm growing projects in Kalangala, the inflow of money to those who engaged in the project and those who didn't caused

problems on either side. "Some farmers were overwhelmed by the sudden boom in their financial fortunes and they started misbehaving. Husbands started having extra marital affairs, resulting in fights among couples and rise in the spread of HIV/AIDS. On the other hand, families that didn't benefit from the project continued to suffer with poverty and food insecurity. We had to do something to change that," says Jackson Baguma, the District Production Marketing Officer (DPMO).

A New Dawn for Couples

When the government launched a nationwide crackdown on illegal fishing activities, many families lost their sole source of livelihood. This was the case for Moses Temwa, Florence Nanyondo and their two young children. Temwa worked as a fish dealer while Nanyondo fried and

sold fish in the local trading center. Even though their lives were far from perfect, losing a source of income plunged them into extreme poverty and despair which almost resulted in the breaking up of their marriage. "As a man, waking up with nothing to do and nowhere to get food for your family is depressing. Most of my capital was confiscated by the authorities, which sent me back to zero. So, when we heard about the mentorship program on the radio, my wife and I prayed that we would benefit from it," Temwa says.

The family's prayers were answered when officials from the Local Council's office and NOPP visited their home and assigned them a household mentor, Nankubuge Mugagga. "As a household mentor for Kalaga Town Council, I am trained to handle 10 households at a time. I dedicate time to each family in order to identify the cause of conflict, suggest solutions,



develop an action plan and implement it. This process involves all family members, including the children because they also face these difficulties every day,” says Mugagga.

Within a period of six months, working with their household mentor, Temwa and his family managed to come up with a solid plan to diversify their income and solve food insecurity in their home. With support from the project, the family exchanged their bull for a cow which was later inseminated artificially. The milk from the cow provided a daily source of income and food. Nanyondo took on backyard farming which she supplemented with poultry, piggery and goat rearing. With the help of artificial insemination, she has been able to multiply her goats and pigs, paving the way for a future small-scale farm of her own.

“We are happier and closer as a family since we enrolled in this project. The charts we drew with our mentor and the children show the roadmap to transforming our lives. This intervention was a blessing from God,” the couple testify in unison.

Widespread Impact

The success of the household mentorship programme has resonated well with the residents of Kalangala hence its widespread impact.

“When the programme was first introduced, we trained 50 household mentors (25 women, 25 men), each capable of handling 10 families, translating to a capacity of 500 households. Our first cohort received only 240 households because some people were hesitant to join. But after seeing the transformation of the first beneficiaries, they embraced the programme and that is why currently we are mentoring at full capacity,” Musaaizi explains.

There are 60 non-oil palm farmer groups and Village Saving and Lending Associations which have been formed as a result of the household mentoring programme. To further boost their resilience and sustainability, project officials have linked them to the Alternative Livelihood Programme, Parish Development Model and other government poverty eradication projects.



RENT TO OWN LAND SCHEME PROPELS KALANGALA OIL PALM FARMER TO PROSPERITY



Teddy Nalutaaya displays harvest from her oil palm garden.

Opportunities have not always been in abundance for the residents of Kalangala District in Central Uganda. For many years, Kalangala which comprises of 84 islands remained vastly underdeveloped due to its separation from the mainland by Lake Victoria. Unemployment, poor infrastructure, poverty and a high HIV/AIDS prevalence ran rampant across the islands. For many youths, Senior Four was the highest level of education they could achieve before being forced to drop out due to lack of funds.

In 2010, Teddy Nalutaaya dropped out of school in Senior Five due to her family's lack of school fees. However, her father gave her two acres from the family plot which she has since turned into a thriving oil palm empire, uplifting herself and her family from poverty to sustainable wealth.

"When I first started oil palm growing in 2010, my original goal was to earn school fees and return to school. However, this is not a business for quick cash. I didn't begin earning from it until 2014. This was the first time I ever earned a million shillings that was mine. Instead of returning to school, I used the money to acquire 14 more acres of land under a rent-to-own scheme and planted my second oil palm garden in 2015," Nalutaaya narrates.

With technical support, extension services, oil palm seedlings and other farm inputs at subsidized loan rates from the project, Nalutaaya was able to thrive. The project was highly successful in booting the economy and livelihood of oil palm farmers in Kalangala that it motivated the introduction of the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) to extend all palm growing across Uganda.

Having already reaped the earlier benefits of growing oil palm, Nalutaaya decided to add 13 more acres of oil palm in March 2023 under the same rent-to-buy land scheme.

"Overall, my journey in oil palm growing has been nothing short of incredible. I have been able to build a house for myself and my parents. I have started a family of my own with a husband and two children who are guaranteed to complete their studies and enjoy better financial life than I did as a child. That is why I decided to include my children as beneficiaries of my newly planted 13-acre oil palm garden under NOPP," Nalutaaya says with a smile.

Under the new model of NOPP, oil palm farmers have much better technical support, access to the latest agro-inputs, and better market-financial control





through their cooperative, Sesse Oilpalm Farmers Cooperative Society Ltd. Under the project's tripartite agreement, all oil palm growers in Kalangala are registered members who own shares in KOPGT as well as the investor company, OPUL (Oil Palm Uganda Limited). In return, OPUL which owns a mill and oil palm production company guarantees a ready market for all KOPGT harvests at competitive market prices. This has resulted in massive financial benefits for the farmers and propelled the oil palm industry into one of the top income and revenue generators in Uganda.

Nalutaaya's harvestable 16-acre farm now provides her with an estimated income of UGX10 to UGX15m per month, and it is capable of remaining harvestable for up to 30 years. This has enabled her to pay 90 percent of the purchasing fee for her 14-acre farm and also fund the setting up the new 13-acre farm. She employs three full time farm workers who earn UGX 150,000 per month, and several others when the need arises to carry out harvesting, pruning, planting and other extra farm duties.

With backing from KOPGT's farmer owned savings and credit society (Ssesse Oil Palm Growers Cooperative Savings and Credit Society Ltd – SOPGA), Nalutaaya has access to low interest loans which are financed by her monthly oil palm harvests. "As farmers, we no longer worry about money and high interest loans from banks. We have our own scheme that caters for our needs and whose profits continue to benefit oil palm farmers. For this, I am thankful to the government, KOPGT, OPUL and all other entities involved in the NOPP. They have contributed to the improvement of our lives," she says.



KALANGALA OIL PALM FARMERS EARNED UGX 268 BILLION FROM SALES SINCE 2010 – KOPGT BOSS BALIRONDA.



David Balironda, the General Manager of Kalangala Oil Palm Growers Trust (KOPGT)

The story of oil palm growing in Uganda can never be fully told without discussing the island district of Kalangala. Working as a District Development Officer in the late 90s, David Balironda wrote the original concept note for commercial oil palm growing in Kalangala and the rest of the country. Some refer to him as “Jajja weebinazi mu Uganda”, loosely translated as “the grandfather of oil palm in Uganda”.

Today Balironda serves as the General Manager (GM) of Kalangala Oil Palm Growers Trust (KOPGT), one of the largest and most profitable farmers’ cooperatives in the country. Boasting a membership of 2,213 farmers and a cumulative planted hectareage of 5,891 hectares, the latest financial figures released by KOPGT illustrate the economic impact and potential of oil palm growing in Uganda. From 2010 when the first harvest was realized to June 2023, oil palm farmers

under KOPGT have earned a cumulative income of UGX 268 billion from the sale of Fresh Fruit Bunches (FFB) thanks to a tripartite agreement facilitated by the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) and its predecessor, the Vegetable Oil Development Project (VODP).

“The latest figures from our performance report are a testament to our long-term faith in the potential of oil palm growing in Kalangala. Since the inception of KOPGT in 2006, we have transformed oil palm growing into a gold mine for the farmers,” Balironda explains.

The NOPP is a government initiative funded by the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) and implemented by the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF) in partnership with other agencies. Under NOPP, MAAIF, KOPGT and an investor company, Oil

Palm Uganda Limited (OPUL) agreed on a working relationship to respectively ensure; the regulation of the oil palm sector; unionizing of farmers; and the efficient production of crude oil palm and its products, effectively setting in place streamlined system of supply and demand with the farmers at the core of it.

“OPUL set up an oil palm mill and nucleus garden which provides farmers with high quality seedlings. In addition, farmers also receive fertilizers, technical support, garden clearing and maintenance funds which are subsidized and repaid in affordable installations by farmers when they begin harvesting. This scheme combined with a government loan of UGX 53 billion were the foundations we needed to propel KOPGT to the top,” says Balironda.



Key Statistics from KOPGT Performance Report (2010 – June 2023)



Current cumulative hectares planted by smallholder farmers in Kalangala:

5,891 hectares



Cumulative FFB production

389,923,905 kgs

Total number of smallholder farmers under KOPGT:

2,213



839 (38%)
1,305 (59%)



69 (3%)

Production per acre:

511kgs
2020

531kgs
2021

456kgs
2022

487kgs
2023

KOPGT owns

10% shares in OPUL
worth UGX 42.6 billion.

Average FFB Price per kilogram:

UGX 579
2020

UGX 917
2021

UGX 1,137
2022

UGX 882
2023

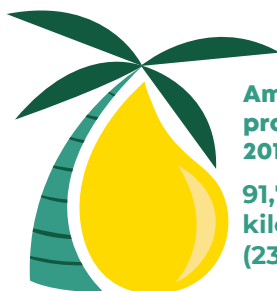
Average farmers earnings per acre, per month

UGX 294,435
2020

UGX 485,162
2021

UGX 530,090
2022

UGX 519,726
2023



Amount of oil produced since 2010:

91,753,498 kilograms
(23% of 337m kgs)



Cumulative farmers income from FFB sales:

UGX 268 billion.

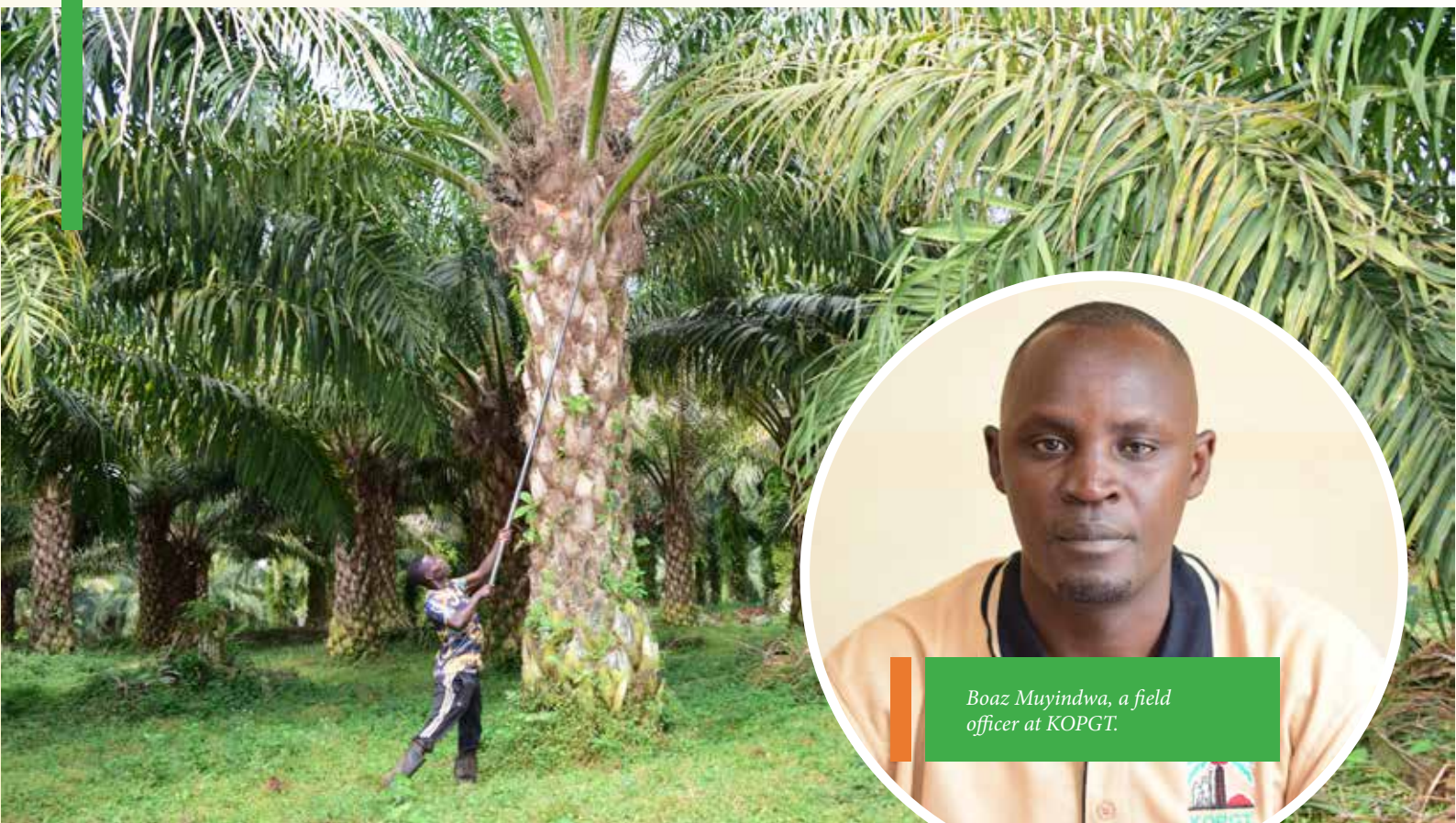
KOPGT has repaid

90% of the **UGX 53 billion**

loan acquired from government at the start of the project.



BENEFITS OF GROWING OIL PALM IN KALANGALA



Boaz Muyindwa, a field officer at KOPGT.

The economic transformation of Kalangala and its residents due to oil palm growing tops the list of benefits. According to Jackson Baguma, the District Production Marketing Officer (DPMO) for Kalangala, “residents can now afford high quality education for their children, construct good permanent houses, pay for household utilities and own family cars. This is in a space of less than 18 years since the introduction of oil palm growing speaks volumes to how impactful this project has been,” says Baguma.

Infrastructure development: Proceeds from the oil palm economy have directly resulted in the establishment of new infrastructure both by government and the private stakeholders. Kalangala now has three modern ferries that transport people and goods to and from the island on a daily and hourly basis unlike before when it had one ferry. MV Kalangala connects from Nakiwogo Landing Site in Entebbe to Kalangala once a day, while MV Sesse and MV Pearl connect from Bukakata Landing Site in Masaka to Kalangala on

an hourly basis from morning to evening. A total of 600km of all-weather roads including community and farm access roads were constructed under the VODP project, which has boosted mobility and economic activity on the island.

Alternative livelihoods: As a result of the success of the oil palm growing initiative, Kalangala has emerged as a major revenue generator in other aspects. These include tourism, fishing, fruits and vegetable farming, livestock farming, and hospitality among others. This has created thousands of new jobs in addition to those related to the oil palm growing industry such as extension work, driving, weeding, harvesting, basket weaving and broom making from oil palm leaves.

Professionalization of farming: “Before the establishment of VODP and its clearcut structure, the majority of the farmers in Kalangala were under subsistence farming, meaning their chances of escaping poverty were limited. Oil palm growing has changed the perception and prospects of what it means to be a farmer.

Our farmers now have health and other insurance. They can walk into a bank or their SACCO and acquire loans in a short time. The farmers of today receive the latest agricultural inputs and technical support, unlike before. All of this has been brought about by oil palm growing,” says Boaz Muyindwa, a field officer at KOPGT.

Environmental preservation: Due to its massive influence, the oil palm project has played an exemplary role in the preservation and rejuvenation of Kalangala’s natural beauty. All the acreage of oil palm field respects and takes into account a 200m buffer between the lake, forest reserves and other gazetted areas. KOPGT and OPUL have supported the appropriate planting of cover crops and food crops which create a bio mass of the ground and mitigate soil erosion. This combined with the planting of new trees has helped secure the future of Kalangala’s natural resources.





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